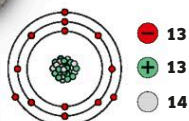


Atomic structure



ALUMINUM

Aluminium

Discovered: 1825

Light and easy to shape, this metal is the main part of alloys used for anything from kitchen foil to aircraft parts. Much of it is recycled, as extracting it from mineral ores to produce pure metal is expensive and very energy-consuming.

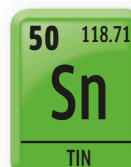


TIN

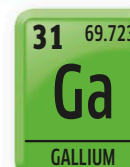
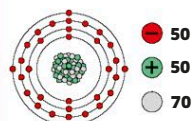
Stannum

Discovered: c. 3000 BCE

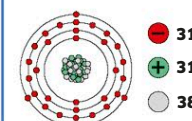
Tin was once smelted with copper to produce the alloy bronze—which led to the Bronze Age. Today it is used in alloys to plate other metal objects, such as pots and “tin cans.”



Atomic structure



Atomic structure



GALLIUM

Gallium

Discovered: 1875

Famous as an element with a melting point at just above room temperature, gallium metal melts in your hand. In commercial applications, gallium is a vital element in the production of semi-conductors for use in electronics.

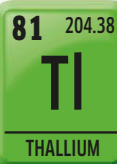


THALLIUM

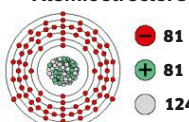
Thallium

Discovered: 1861

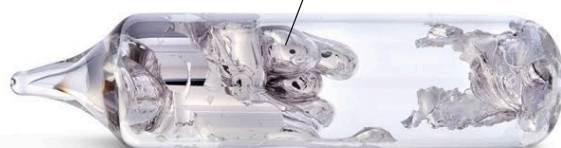
This soft, silvery metal is toxic in its pure state. It was commonly put to use as rat poison, but sometimes ended up killing humans, too. Combined with other elements it can be useful, for example to improve the performance of lenses.



Atomic structure



Toxic thallium in its pure form, safely kept in a vial.

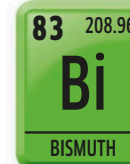
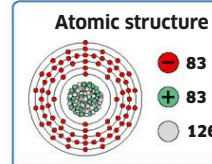


BISMUTH

Bismuthum

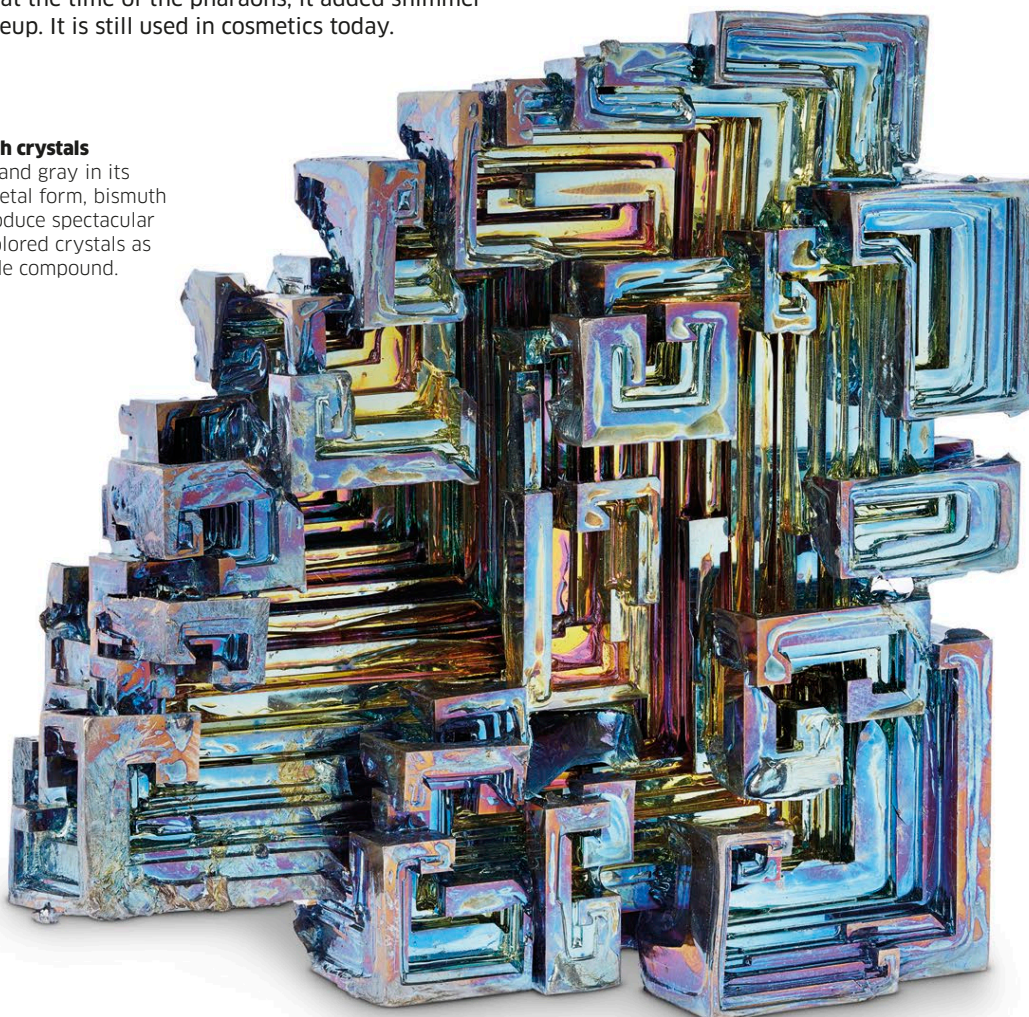
Discovered: 1753

Bismuth is a curious element. It is what is known as a heavy metal, similar to lead, but not very toxic. It is a tiny bit radioactive. It was not defined as an individual element until the 18th century, but has been known and used as a material since ancient times. For example in Egypt, at the time of the pharaohs, it added shimmer to makeup. It is still used in cosmetics today.



Bismuth crystals

Brittle and gray in its pure metal form, bismuth can produce spectacular multicolored crystals as an oxide compound.

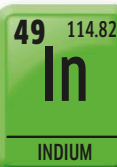


INDIUM

Indium

Discovered: 1863

A very soft metal in its pure state, indium is part of the alloy indium tin oxide, or ITO. This material is used in touch screens, LCD TV screens, and as a reflective coating for windows.



Atomic structure

